A Manual of Harmony

Author: Ernst Friedrich Richter | *Authorized Translation*

Chapter I: The Construction of Fundamental Triads

Harmony is the science of chords and their sequential relationship. The foundation of harmonic theory rests upon the triad. A triad is a chord consisting of three tones: a fundamental root, a third above the root, and a fifth above the root.

The Major Triad: Formed by a root, a major third (4 semitones), and a perfect fifth (7 semitones). In C major, this is C – E – G. The triad provides tonal resolution and acoustic clarity.

The Minor Triad: Formed by a root, a minor third (3 semitones), and a perfect fifth (7 semitones). In A minor, this is A – C – E.

The Diminished Triad: Formed by a root, a minor third (3 semitones), and a diminished fifth (6 semitones). For example, on the seventh degree of C major: B – D – F. Note: The diminished triad contains a diminished fifth, NOT a perfect fifth.

The Augmented Triad: Formed by a root, a major third (4 semitones), and an augmented fifth (8 semitones). For example: C – E – G#.

Chapter II: Inversions of the Triad

When the fundamental root tone is in the lowest voice (bass), the chord is in its fundamental root position. When another tone is placed in the bass, the chord is in an inversion.

The First Inversion (Chord of the Sixth, 6/3): When the third of the triad is placed in the lowest voice (bass), the chord is in the First Inversion. The intervals above the bass are a third and a sixth; hence it is denoted as the Chord of the Sixth, or figured as 6 or 6/3. In C major, with E in the bass, the chord is E – G – C, represented as I6.

The Second Inversion (Chord of the Sixth and Fourth, 6/4): When the fifth of the triad is placed in the lowest voice (bass), the chord is in the Second Inversion. The intervals above the bass are a fourth and a sixth; hence it is designated the Chord of the Fourth and Sixth, or figured as 6/4. In C major, with G in the bass, the chord is G – C – E, represented as I6/4. The 6/4 chord has an unstable, dependent character and frequently functions as a cadential 6/4 delaying the dominant V.

Chapter III: Principles of Four-Part SATB Voice Leading

The standard choral setting consists of four voices: Soprano, Alto, Tenor, and Bass (abbreviated SATB). The soprano and alto are high voices; the tenor and bass are lower voices.

The Prohibition of Parallel Fifths and Octaves: One of the most foundational and strict laws of classical part writing is: Consecutive parallel fifths and parallel octaves between any two voices are strictly prohibited. If two voices sound a perfect fifth (or perfect octave) and move in parallel motion to another perfect fifth (or octave), the independence of the two voices is destroyed.

Contrary Motion: Contrary motion, in which voices move in opposite directions, provides the most effective protection against parallel fifths and octaves.

Leading Tone Resolution: The leading tone (seventh degree, ^7) possesses an energetic tendency to resolve upward by step to the tonic (^1). In cadences, the leading tone in an outer voice must resolve upward.

Chapter IV: Harmonic Cadences

A cadence is a harmonic progression that marks the close of a musical phrase, section, or complete composition.

The Perfect Authentic Cadence (PAC): The most conclusive harmonic close is the Perfect Authentic Cadence. It requires: 1. The harmonic progression from the Dominant (V) to the Tonic (I). 2. Both chords must be in fundamental root position. 3. The highest voice (soprano) must arrive on the tonic root pitch (^1) in the final chord.

The Imperfect Authentic Cadence (IAC): An Authentic Cadence is termed Imperfect if either chord is in an inversion (e.g., V6 to I, or V to I6), or if the soprano voice ends on the third (^3) or fifth (^5) of the tonic chord instead of the root.

The Half Cadence (HC): A Half Cadence pauses upon the Dominant chord (V), typically preceded by the tonic (I to V), subdominant (IV to V), or supertonic (ii to V).

The Deceptive Cadence (DC): A Deceptive Cadence occurs when the dominant chord (V) leads not to the expected tonic (I), but to another scale degree, most frequently the submediant (vi). In C major, this is the progression V to vi.